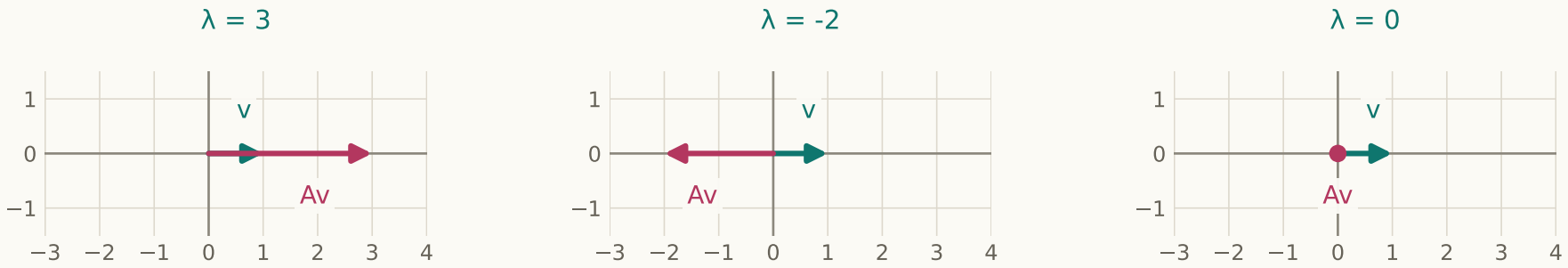Eigenvalues describe what happens on the line